

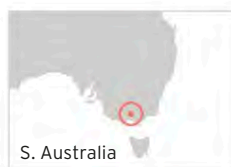
# Royal Exhibition Building

*A palace of culture, which signaled the arrival of Melbourne as a vital metropolis*

As the self-governing Australian states of Victoria and New South Wales grew richer after the gold booms of the 1850s, rivalry between their respective capitals of Melbourne and Sydney intensified. Both wished to organize exhibitions modeled on the international exhibitions of Europe, a craze begun with the Great Exhibition in London in 1851. Sydney won the race and opened its fair in October 1879, but concentrated mainly on agriculture. Melbourne therefore decided to launch its more international-looking fair after Sydney's had ended, and the building opened on May 29, 1880.

## Exhibitions, parliaments, and sports

The exhibition was held in a vast building designed in cruciform style by the architect Joseph Reed. Its eclectic exterior included a dome modeled on that of Florence Cathedral (see pp.140–141) and elements of Byzantine, Romanesque, and Renaissance styles. After the exhibition closed on April 30, 1881, the building was used as the temporary home for the first Parliament of Australia in May 1901, and later as a venue for basketball and other sports during the 1956 Olympic Games. The first building in Australia to be listed as a World Heritage Site by UNESCO, the building is currently used as a commercial exhibition venue.

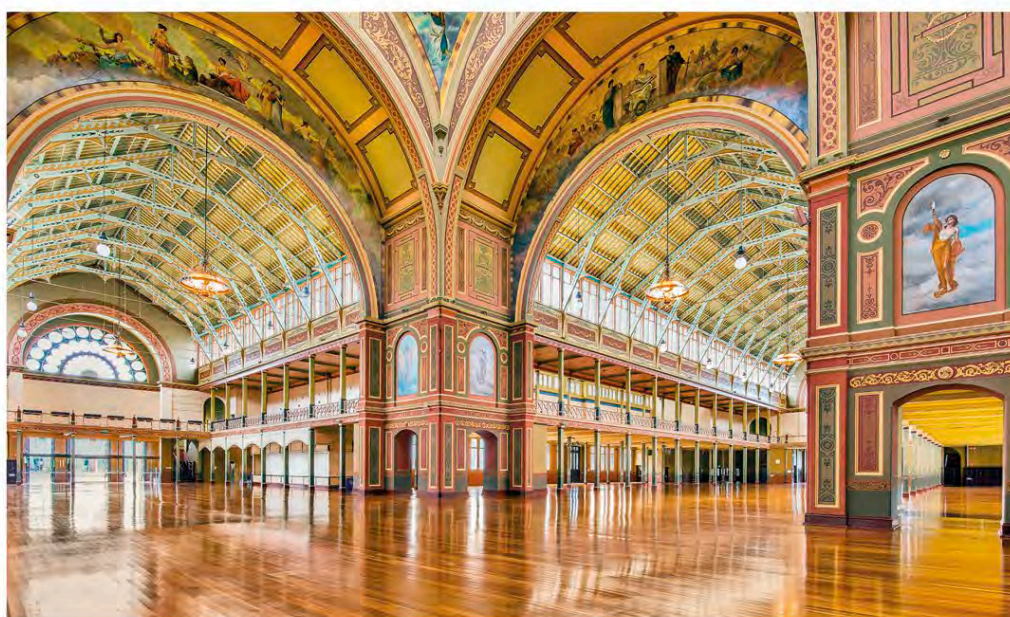


### △ THE GREAT DOME

The dome at the center of the building was built from cast iron and rendered stone. It rises 223 ft (68 m) high and is 60 ft (18 m) wide.

### ▽ MAIN HALL

The four branches of the main hall meet under the dome. High windows shed light on the opulent interior, covered with murals that represent the virtues of a new Australia.



**1.3 million people** visited the building during the **exhibition of 1880–1881**



## BUILDING THE BRIDGE

Once the two abutment towers were built, cranes were used to construct the main arch. When the two sides of the arch met in the middle, vertical hangers and horizontal crossbeams for the roadway were put in place from the center to the sides.

